

BOOKS OF THE TIMES

BOOKS OF THE TIMES; In a Mississippi Town, a Little Boy's Murder Spells the Death of a Family

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THE LITTLE FRIEND

By Donna Tartt

555 pages. Alfred A. Knopf. \$26.

When it was published in 1992, Donna Tartt's debut novel, "The Secret History," became an immediate sensation. An enthralling gothic thriller about a group of effete college students and their involvement in two murders, the novel managed to be cerebral and gripping, self-consciously literary and ferociously entertaining at the same time, and it quickly became a cult best seller.

Her ungainly new novel, "The Little Friend," belongs to the same cross-genre of literary thriller-cum-bildungsroman, but it couldn't be more different in mood or execution. It takes place in a small Mississippi town, far removed from the snooty college depicted in that earlier book, and its literary polestars, Robert Louis Stevenson and Harper Lee's "To Kill a Mockingbird," stand in sharp contrast to the books that informed "The Secret History," Evelyn Waugh's "Brideshead Revisited" and Euripides' "Bacchae."

"The Little Friend" also turns out to be a far more emotionally resonant novel than its predecessor, and a much less satisfying thriller: awkwardly plotted, if keenly observed, and speckled with glittering set pieces that do not add up to a persuasive whole. It is a kind of changeling creature, neither caterpillar nor moth but something still in chrysalis, waiting to be born.

At its best, it attests to the maturation of the author's voice and her willingness to push her gifts in an ambitious new direction, to explore the intimacies of family and small-town life, the peculiar geography of childhood in all its dreamlike intensity and ennui, and the perils of storytelling and trying to mythologize the past. At its worst, it feels like a Frankenstein of a book, a lumpish collection of mismatched parts that even the author's virtuosic talents cannot transform into a coherent whole.

The novel begins with a harrowing prologue that recounts the death of a 9-year-old boy named Robin, who is found hanging, dead, from a tupelo tree in his family's yard one Sunday evening. This horrifying tabloid event will utterly alter the Cleve family's daily life. Charlotte, his mother, withdraws into a drug-induced stupor; his father, Dix, takes a job in another city and effectively cuts himself off from his family; his grandmother Edie turns increasingly cynical and sour; his sister Allison becomes a frightened, passive girl, given to bad dreams; and his baby sister, Harriet, develops an obsession with avenging his death.

The remainder of the book is far less fluent and poised than the prologue and takes place 12 years later. Harriet has become a spirited tomboy: part Scout (from "To Kill a Mockingbird") in her inquisitiveness, part Scarlett O'Hara in her willfulness and spunk. She is smart, rude, impulsive, uncompromising and bossy. She is also an ardent reader of adventure stories, and possesses both a theatrical imagination and her family's penchant for rewriting the past, that "narrowness of vision which enabled all the Cleves to forget what they didn't want to remember, and to exaggerate or otherwise alter what they couldn't forget." They are traits, we are portentously warned, that will get Harriet into a great deal of trouble.

Harriet soon becomes convinced that one of Robin's former schoolmates, a scruffy redneck named Danny Ratliff, is behind Robin's death, and she persuades her best friend, the worshipful Hely, to help her plot her revenge. Though Harriet is repeatedly warned to keep her distance from Danny and his family -- which bears more than a passing resemblance to Dostoevsky's Karamazov clan -- she and Hely are soon tailing Danny and his brothers, one of whom, the dangerously unstable Farish, is operating an illegal crystal meth lab.

Her plan is to get her hands on a poisonous snake and use it to kill Danny. Meanwhile Danny, who is in some ways Harriet's dark doppelgänger, has begun to suffer from speed-induced paranoia and delusions and has become fixated on the strange little dark-haired girl who keeps popping up in his life.

In "The Secret History," Ms. Tartt managed to make even more melodramatic and bizarre events (involving Dionysian rites and intimations of satanic power) seem entirely plausible, but this time around her storytelling is considerably less assured. While there are a series of thrilling sequences in this novel (involving Harriet and Hely's attempt to steal a cobra, their efforts to throw the snake into Danny's car, and Harriet's investigation of Farish's secret drug stash), these

scenes feel like outtakes from a highly contrived action movie. They neither radiate a genuine sense of inevitability nor click together cleverly to form a pleasing narrative arc.

The strongest portions of "The Little Friend" deal not with Harriet's vigilante actions but with her mundane, day-to-day life: her contentious relationship with her sickly, woebegone mother; her affectionate reliance on the family housekeeper, Ida, who is summarily let go after decades of service; her loving, if sometimes embattled relationships with her grandmother and great-aunts. Ms. Tartt's portrait of the Cleve family possesses all the detail and luminosity of an old platinum photograph: she chronicles their emotional history, their mortgaged dreams and their intramural squabbles with consummate ease while showing us how familial traits and inclinations are handed down generation to generation, mother to daughter, aunt to niece.

Most of all, she makes palpable the losses that the family has sustained over the years: we are made to understand how Robin's murder, Ida's departure and the death of her great-aunt Libby have affected Harriet, and how these events have goaded her to seek refuge in the dangerous fantasy of avenging Robin's death. Ms. Tartt has also tried to show how very different sorts of disappointments have shaped the life of Danny Ratliff, but her attempts to dovetail the stories of these two desperate characters -- one, a bitter and violent speed freak, the other a feisty 12-year-old girl -- feel mechanical and forced, a high-concept Hollywood notion that proves to be a poor showcase for this writer's rich and variegated gifts.

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